BUSINESS AI STACK · CHAPTER 26

Zoho CRM

A practical guide with steps, examples and a checklist. Read the chapter, then build the example.

CHAPTER 26 · BUSINESS AI STACK

Zoho CRM: managing customers and leads

A CRM (customer relationship management) system keeps every lead, customer and conversation in one place, with a clear next step for each one.

What Zoho CRM does for a small business

- **Leads and contacts.** Every enquiry becomes a lead, which becomes a contact once you talk to them.
- **Deals (pipeline).** Each sales opportunity moves through stages, such as New, Contacted, Demo, Proposal and Won or Lost.
- **Tasks and follow-ups.** A reminder for each lead, so nobody is forgotten.
- **Reports.** How many leads came in, which source they came from, and how many became customers.

Set up a clean pipeline

1. Create a sign-up account and set your company details, time zone and currency.
2. Define the stages. Keep them to five or six, each with a clear exit rule (for example, "Demo booked" means a date is in the calendar).
3. Add the lead fields you really use: source, interest, budget range, preferred time. Avoid fields nobody fills in.
4. Create lead-assignment rules, so each new lead goes to one person with a response deadline.
5. Connect your website form and WhatsApp (Chapter 27) with an automation tool such as n8n or Make, so leads arrive without copy-paste.

Connecting Zoho to the rest of the stack

Zoho provides its own APIs and connectors. A common pattern: the website form saves the lead to Supabase, an n8n workflow creates the lead in Zoho through the Zoho API, and the same workflow sends a WhatsApp confirmation. Check the current Zoho API documentation for the exact endpoints and the authentication method before you build.

DATA HYGIENE

Remove duplicates once a month, record consent for marketing messages, and give customers a way to opt out. These protect you and keep the pipeline honest.

Metrics to watch

- Lead response time (target: within one working hour).
- Conversion from each stage to the next.
- Lead source that brings the most paying customers, not just the most leads.

Reference: Zoho CRM help and developer documentation. Plan limits and prices change; check the current plan page.